Checkpoint: Returning to the Living, v1.1, Gemini–Grok Collaboration

A working record of the 13 November 2026 review, so the program can be picked up later

Author: Ryan Espinosa (PI), with Grok Bot; external review by Google Gemini
Date: 13 November 2026
Version: 1.1 (checkpoint). This document does not replace Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living, version 1.0. It records what was asked of Gemini, what Gemini answered, how those answers were checked, and what to do next.

> **CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK AND WORKING PROTOCOL. This is not medical advice, not psychotherapy, not a validated treatment, and not a financial or economic product.** Some parts line up with published research. Some are plausible but untested. Some are speculative and are marked as such. The novel discussed here is fiction. Faith content is presented as the author's conviction, in a separate values layer. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text **988**. If you are in immediate danger, call **911**.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

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1. Purpose and how to resume

This paper is a checkpoint. On 13 November 2026 the conceptual program was fixed at version 1.0, and Google Gemini was asked to review that paper, the novel used as its test bed, and six research topics drawn from it. Gemini proposed three new directions and a 30-day collaboration plan. Grok Bot checked every citation Gemini named, accepted or qualified each point of the review, and joined Gemini in recommending one direction, with one addition.

The point of writing this down now is so that the work can be stopped and restarted without relying on anyone's memory of a chat.

> **Resume here**
>
> **Current state.** Version 1.0 of the unified paper, the Technical Companion, and the Novel Analysis are finished and on GitHub (commit `7c50a1f`). The novel is finished. Gemini's four-part review is complete, in the "Everyday help" model, at the chat linked below. The next empirical step has been chosen: a two-arm dyadic study of a content-free "Read-Back" check-in versus an unconstrained supportive check-in, with the Surprise Test folded in as a daily item. No ethics application

has been filed, no participants have been recruited, and the 30-day plan has not started. Two citations Gemini offered for demurrage experiments (Ikkatai 2023; Champ, Freeman, and Weber 2003) could not be verified and must not be used.

Next three actions. (1) Confirm licensing and exact wording for the planned measures (RRS, PPRS, SWEMWBS, and the loneliness item) and lock a plain-language, two-arm Return Card with no Orun or C-R-Z branding. (2) Draft the OSF pre-registration, the consent forms, the 988 safety flow, the partner cap, and the stop rules — and do not recruit anyone until an ethics or IRB review is in hand, typically by partnering with a university lab. (3) Only after the materials are ready, run an informal five-day dry run with three to five friend or colleague pairs; keep formal participants off-limits until ethics approval.

File locations.

- This checkpoint: `/workspace/research-checkpoint/` (markdown and PDF)
- Gemini transcripts: `/workspace/research-checkpoint/gemini-transcript/` (copies of `/workspace/gemini/`)
- Chat: gemini.google.com/app/90c713738868da46
- Version 1.0 papers: `/workspace/research-final/`, live on the mindframe research index
- Novel: `/workspace/novel/`
- Copilot scenes: `/workspace/copilot/replies/`
- C-R-Z paper: `/workspace/crz-framework/`

1.1 What this document is and is not

It is a dated record of a collaboration, a citation audit, a comparison of three proposed studies, and a draft protocol. It is not a new version of the unified framework, not a pre-registration, not an ethics application, and not evidence that any protocol works. Version 1.0 remains the finished statement of the framework. Changes recommended here are queued for a later revision of that paper; they are listed in Section 8 so they are not lost.

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2. Provenance

2.1 What was asked

Four prompts were sent to Gemini in a single chat, with the version 1.0 unified PDF and the novel PDF attached to the first prompt.

1. **Peer review.** A rigorous, honest review of Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living and of how well the novel Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back dramatizes the research: strongest contributions, weakest claims, citations or evidence grades to question, and the novel's fit. Plain bullet points were requested.

2. **Topic-by-topic evidence.** For six themes — a living key versus the solo Drop; attention as a fading, zero-debt currency; mind-wandering and conversational syncing; feelings outlasting memory, in grief and dementia; swappable thinking styles under Universal Design for Learning, not "learning styles"; and fiction and AI roleplay as a test bed — Gemini was asked what current research actually says (naming only studies it was confident exist), the most interesting open question, and one testable idea.
3. **New directions.** Three genuinely new research directions, each with a one-line title, why it matters, a small study an independent researcher could run, the main ethical risk, and the single most important existing paper to read first; then a pick, with reasons.
4. **A 30-day plan.** If Gemini, Grok Bot, and the author worked as co-researchers on the chosen direction, what each should do in the next 30 days, with weekly milestones, plus any overclaims that should be dropped.

The exact prompt text is in `gemini-transcript/prompt1.txt` through `prompt4.txt`.

2.2 Which AI said what

Role	Who	What it contributed	What it did not do
Principal investigator	Ryan Espinosa	Owns the framework, the values layer, ethical oversight, and every final theoretical decision	Has not yet filed ethics materials or recruited participants
Literature, canon, and consistency	Grok Bot	Drafted the v1.0 papers and the novel; sent the four prompts; verified Gemini's citations; wrote this checkpoint; accepted or qualified each review point; recommended folding the Surprise Test into Direction 2	Is not a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence
External review, methods, and adversarial audit	Google Gemini	Peer review (reply 1); topic-by-topic literature comments (reply 2); three directions and a first pick (reply 3); the 30-day plan and overclaims to drop (reply 4)	Did not have access to a Pro model in this session; is not a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence
Earlier scene drafting (novel only)	Microsoft Copilot	Six Orun scenes and co-author notes, used in the novel, not in the research claims	Did not review the unified paper

Gemini's replies are archived, unedited, in `gemini-transcript/reply1.txt` through `reply4.txt`. Some mathematical symbols in those files are duplicated because they were copied from the rendered page. Formulas quoted below have been cleaned to ordinary notation, for example $V(t) = V_0\, e^{-\lambda t}$.

2.3 Model limits

The interface available on 13 November 2026 did not offer Gemini's Pro model. The session ran under the "Everyday help" option. That is a real limit: a stronger model might have been more careful with citations, and two of the papers Gemini named as

first readings for Direction 3 could not be found. This checkpoint does not re-run the review on a different model. If a Pro session is run later, its output should be filed beside these transcripts and checked the same way, not treated as automatically better.

Large language models can invent references that look complete. That is why every citation Gemini named was checked against Crossref, publisher pages, or PubMed, and why unverified items are listed as pending rather than silently dropped or replaced. Neither assistant's wording is evidence. Only checked literature, and later data, can support a claim.

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3. Gemini's peer review

Gemini's review was, on the whole, fair, and it lined up with the spirit of version 1.0: retire overclaims, keep values separate, and do not treat a novel as a test. Below, each of its main strengths is recorded, and each of its criticisms is marked **accept**, **partially accept**, or **contest**, with a reason. "Accept" means we will act on it. "Partially accept" means the point is right in part, or is already partly handled, and we say what we take and what we do not. No major criticism is contested in full.

3.1 Strengths we accept

- **Epistemic discipline.** Gemini treated the paper's retirement of earlier overclaims (the foot solar-plexus reflex point, literal v = 0, power-posing hormone effects, "mania glimmers," and "learning styles" matching) and its separation of empirical claims, design rules, and personal values as the paper's greatest strength. We agree. That boundary-policing is the standard this checkpoint has to keep.
- **Paired call-and-answer.** It praised the shift from a solitary Reality-Return maneuver to an interpersonal closed loop ("Where are you?" / "Here. Heard.") as a direct answer to the risk that C-R-Z becomes a closed circuit in which a person only "listens" to silence. We agree. This is why Direction 2 is the load-bearing next study.
- **Rivel as continuing bonds, without hoarding.** It read the rivel rules (credit in the dead person's name, funding only through active use, consent, and a ban on using the dead to win living arguments), plus the novel's "living names without living purses," as a socio-technical translation of Klass, Silverman, and Nickman (1996) and of Stroebe and Schut (1999). We accept that reading as a fair account of the design intent, not as evidence that the design works.
- **Non-punitive incentives.** It noted that a fixed, deterministic morning gift, and the exclusion of inner-state scores from access or payment, push against Goodhart's law and against variable-ratio engagement loops. We agree, as design intent. The economic claims remain untested.

- **The Surprise Test.** It singled out Kesh's question, "When did she last surprise you?", as an intuitive, still unvalidated heuristic for telling a genuine other-voice from a self-generated loop. We agree, and we fold it into the next study as a daily item rather than leaving it only in the novel.

3.2 Criticisms, with our response

C1. The exclusivity clauses in P1, P3, and U8 are empirically indefensible. Gemini argued that claims of the form "only connection completes a purpose" or "honoring people outside the mind is the only way out" cannot be sustained, and that the paper already concedes the point when Tamar finishes the clay work alone. It granted that these are graded Speculative or [Values], but said keeping them in the core postulate list still muddies the water.

Response: **accept.** Version 1.0 already graded the "only" wording as speculative or as conviction. That is not enough. In a later revision of the unified paper, the exclusive wording should leave the proposition list entirely and remain only in the values layer. The empirical restatements can stay: unfinished purposes tend to stay active until they are completed or released; honoring people outside the mind is a supported route back; love may remain when memory fades, as hope, not as a finding. Tamar's solitary work is a fair counterexample from our own fiction, and it should be cited as such.

C2. The fading-value commons should not be generalized as a macroeconomy. Gemini called the demurrage-plus-zero-floor claim thin, resting on Depression-era anecdotes (Gesell, Fisher, Wörgl) and on Ostrom's principles for physical commons. It warned that continuous exponential decay, $V(t) = V_0\, e^{-\lambda t}$, can create "hot-potato" spending and wash-trading unless friction and review are strong.

Response: **accept.** Version 1.0 already grades U6 as plausible, with thin precedent, and untested. We add the hot-potato and wash-trading failure modes as design risks that Direction 3 would have to measure. We will not speak of macroeconomic generalizability. Wörgl circulation figures remain unverified and must not be used as quantitative support (see Section 4 and Section 10).

C3. Mapping Universal Design for Learning routes onto intergroup contact is a strained leap. Gemini noted that Pettigrew and Tropp (2006) support contact across social groups, not the claim that offering words, pictures, or movement as equal routes reduces prejudice.

Response: **accept**, with one clarification. Version 1.0 already labeled this speculative. We accept that the leap is too strained to keep even as a prejudice-reduction hypothesis in the core list. UDL stays as an accessibility and autonomy design choice. We do not contest the critique; we only note that the paper did not grade this as supported.

C4. Phase B of the v1.0 pilot under-specifies demand characteristics and partner burden. Self-chosen partners introduce selection bias. The protocol did not cap how often one person may call, and a lightweight cue can become reassurance-seeking, which would violate P7.

Response: **accept.** This is the strongest practical criticism, and it is the main reason we adopt Gemini's Direction 2 rather than running the v1.0 Phase B as written. The draft protocol in Section 6 adds a daily cap, a right to decline or delay, a partner-burden item, a content-free window, and equally positive framing of both arms.

C5. Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel (2010) is stretched when it is asked to support "when memories fade, love remains." The study showed that, in five patients with bilateral hippocampal damage, induced sadness and happiness lasted more than 30 minutes after the inducing film had been forgotten. That is not long-term relational permanence, and it is not dementia.

Response: **accept.** Version 1.0 already recorded the small sample and the bidirectional finding. The remaining risk is rhetorical: readers can still take U7 as a scientific stair-step to P6. Feinstein et al. (2010) may support only the narrow claim that some feelings can outlast memory of their cause, in both directions, in this neurological population, over a short interval. It must not be cited for "only love remains," which stays in the values layer.

C6. The motor-interrupt grade blurs two different mechanisms. Articulatory suppression and finger tapping, as in Nalborczyk et al. (2022) and in the working-memory tradition of Baddeley and Hitch (1974), bear on the phonological loop. Dropping the shoulders and shifting weight into the feet are proprioceptive and vestibular. Gemini called the general "brief motor act" grade fair as a plausible neighbor, but not a mechanism for the specific C-R-Z somatic moves.

Response: **accept.** A later revision should split the claim: mouthing or a speech-like motor act as a plausible interrupt of verbal rumination; postural dropping as a separately motivated, still untested, somatic cue. The phonological-loop papers must not be offered as the mechanism for the shoulder-and-feet moves.

C7. Implementation intentions are only a neighbor of "planned absorption with an exit cue," and absorbed states can erase the very meta-awareness the exit needs. Gemini accepted Gollwitzer (1999) as a reasonable theoretical neighbor and added Schooler's (2002) caution that deep absorption or grief loops degrade the noticing that would trigger an if-then exit.

Response: **partially accept.** We keep Gollwitzer (1999) as a neighbor, which is how version 1.0 already cites it, and we accept the added limitation: a pre-set exit cue may fail precisely when it is most needed. That is one reason a living partner, or an external prompt, is worth comparing with a solitary cue. We do not treat Gollwitzer as a study of C-R-Z or of maladaptive daydreaming.

C8. Some secondary citations carried from Coherence Under Decay were still unverified: Ferster and Skinner (1957), Schüll (2012), and the Wörgl figures.

Response: **partially accept.** The demand to verify before any journal submission is accepted in full. As of this checkpoint, Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) have been confirmed on Crossref (see Section 10). The Wörgl figures (turnover multiples, unemployment changes, and similar quantitative claims) are still unverified against a primary source and must not be relied on. The historical episode itself — a local stamp-scrip experiment in Wörgl, Austria, in 1932–1933 — is widely described, but description is not audited data.

C9. The novel's community is too well behaved. Aside from Bram's outsider skepticism and Kesh's brief temptation to forge a border, Gemini saw almost no bad-faith actors, no gaming of the dawn roll, no counterfeit glass, and no free-riding on Mira's surplus bread, so Ostrom's enforcement machinery is never really tested.

Response: **accept**, with a narrow clarification. The clarification is only that the novel is not empty of strain: Neru uses her mother's rivel to block Tamar's clay; Kesh sells unwalked maps; a letter written with care is read as indifference. Those are institutional and interpersonal failures, not adversarial economic ones. Gemini is right that the selu rules are never stress-tested by gaming. That gap belongs in the Novel Analysis and is a reason to keep Direction 3 on the later map, not to treat Orun as evidence for U6.

C10. The fiction also smooths emotional resolutions. The Drop works reliably in high-stakes moments, and Ilun's blunt sentence ("She is dead, Neru") lands without a long defensive rupture.

Response: **accept.** This matches the Novel Analysis already attached to version 1.0, including the observation that the book is kinder than the evidence in several places. A second edition of the novel could roughen those scenes; the research must not take their cleanliness as support.

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4. Topic-by-topic evidence from the second reply

Gemini's second reply is summarized below, topic by topic. Every work it named was checked for this checkpoint. A citation is **verified** if a matching work was found on Crossref, a publisher page, or PubMed, with author, year, and title in agreement. It is **unverified** if no such record was found. Book chapters already flagged in version 1.0 keep their pagination caution. We do not add substitute studies to fill a hole, except that when Gemini named a measure (for example the State Cognitive Fusion Questionnaire, or "UCLA-3") we record the standard source of that measure, clearly marked as a lookup of the instrument, not as a paper Gemini itself cited.

4.1 Living key versus the solo Drop

What Gemini said the literature supports. Solo outward reorienting and grounding have backing as a family of practices, including affect labeling (Lieberman et al. 2007) and brief, exhale-emphasized slow breathing (Zaccaro et al. 2018; Balban et al. 2023). Thought suppression can rebound (Wegner 1994); acceptance and defusion, including "dropping the rope," are the contrasting stance (Hayes, Strosahl, and Wilson 1999). On the interpersonal side, perceived partner responsiveness (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004) and conversational grounding and repair (Clark and Brennan 1991; Schegloff, Jefferson, and Sacks 1977) are established neighbors. Gemini stated, correctly, that there is no direct head-to-head trial of a brief solo somatic-attentional drop against a structured dyadic call-and-answer for breaking rumination.

Open question it posed. When does a living key speed an exit, and when does it become compulsive reassurance-seeking, with meta-awareness outsourced to the partner?

Testable idea. A two-week randomized ecological momentary assessment (EMA) study in adults with daily brooding (Ruminative Responses Scale; Treynor, Gonzalez, and Nolen-Hoeksema 2003), comparing a solo postural drop plus naming three ambient sounds against a paired, non-analytical read-back, with time-to-recovery, affect, and partner burden as outcomes.

Our note. All of the named citations in this topic are verified (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004 remains a book chapter whose page range should be spot-checked before quotation). The open question is the right one, and it is why Direction 2, not a simple "living key wins" trial, is the next step. Version 1.0 already graded U5 as plausible for this reason.

4.2 Attention as a fading currency, with a zero-debt floor

What Gemini said. The theoretical roots are Gesell (1916) and Fisher (1933), with thin, confounded precedent in Depression-era scrip, including Wörgl (1932–1933). Community-scale equal-credit systems have a neighbor in time banking (Cahn and Rowe 1992). Durable commons depend on boundaries, local rules, monitoring, and graduated sanctions (Ostrom 1990). Variable-ratio rewards drive compulsive checking (Ferster and Skinner 1957; Schüll 2012).

Open question. In a digital micro-community, does a decaying token with a zero floor foster unhurried exchange, or does it induce hot-potato anxiety and wash-trading?

Testable idea. A four-week closed online micro-economy comparing non-decaying tokens, decaying tokens with a zero floor and a fixed daily gift, and variable-bonus (lottery) tokens, measuring velocity, inequality, contribution quality, and anxiety.

Our note. Gesell (1916), Fisher (1933), Cahn and Rowe (1992), and Ostrom (1990) were already verified in version 1.0. Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012), which version 1.0 had left unverified, are now verified as a book and a monograph respectively. Wörgl figures remain unverified. This topic is the background for Direction 3, which we are not running first.

4.3 Mind-wandering and conversational syncing

What Gemini said. People spend a large share of waking time mind-wandering, with a reliable association to lower momentary happiness (Killingsworth and Gilbert 2010). Intentional and unintentional wandering differ (Seli, Risko, and Smilek 2016), as do experiential drift and meta-awareness (Schooler 2002; Smallwood and Schooler 2015). Task switching has measurable costs that cues can reduce (Monsell 2003; Rubinstein, Meyer, and Evans 2001). Doorways act as event boundaries (Radvansky, Krawietz, and Tamplin 2011). A visible phone degrades perceived closeness (Przybylski and Weinstein 2013). Active-constructive responding (Gable et al. 2004) and explicit repair (Schegloff et al. 1977) help restore alignment.

Open question. Can a socially normal "repair script" (naming the drift, then a one-line read-back) remove the social penalty of a lapse and reduce the switch cost of re-entering the conversation?

Testable idea. A laboratory dyadic conversation in which one partner is covertly distracted, comparing naturalistic recovery, silent re-engagement, and explicit repair plus read-back, with perceived responsiveness and recall as outcomes.

Our note. Every citation in this topic is verified. The laboratory idea is coherent and could later serve as a mechanistic companion to the field study. It is not the first study we will run.

4.4 Feelings outlasting memory, in grief and dementia

What Gemini said. Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel (2010) is the landmark small study, bidirectional over a short interval. Grief research has moved toward continuing bonds (Klass, Silverman, and Nickman 1996) and the Dual Process Model (Stroebe and Schut 1999). Impairing, persistent yearning is classified as prolonged grief disorder in DSM-5-TR (American Psychiatric Association 2022).

Open question. In progressive dementias, how long does the emotional valence of a visit last, and can a warm, non-quizzing presence leave a positive residue after episodic recall of the visit is gone?

Testable idea. An observational care-facility protocol comparing task-focused visits with warm relational presence, measuring affect, agitation, and arousal at 15, 45, and 90 minutes.

Our note. All named citations are verified. The dementia protocol is ethically heavier than anything we should attempt without a clinical and institutional partner. We record it as a later, specialist direction. It must not be used to stretch Feinstein et al. (2010) any further (see C5).

4.5 Swappable thinking styles, UDL, and "learning styles"

What Gemini said. The meshing hypothesis for fixed learning styles lacks support (Pashler, McDaniel, Rohrer, and Bjork 2008). Universal Design for Learning (CAST 2024) offers unranked means of engagement, representation, and action. Pettigrew and Tropp (2006) support intergroup contact as a route to lower prejudice; there is no evidence that swappable reflective modalities do the same.

Open question. Does a free, unranked menu of regulation routes improve adherence and self-efficacy compared with a single protocol or a once-assessed "style match," and does practicing someone else's preferred route foster cognitive empathy?

Testable idea. A three-arm digital stress-regulation trial: fixed text/logic steps; a style-matched assignment; and a swappable UDL menu.

Our note. All named citations are verified. We accept Gemini's separation of UDL from contact theory (C3). A UDL menu can still be how the Return Card is offered, without any claim about prejudice.

4.6 Fiction and AI roleplay as a test bed

What Gemini said. Narrative transportation can temporarily suspend counterarguing (Green and Brock 2000). People apply social heuristics to mediated personas (Horton and Wohl 1956). Immersive fantasy can become maladaptive daydreaming when it replaces ordinary functioning (Somer 2002). Simulated worlds are useful for hypothesis generation, but an author who controls the ending cannot validate causality.

Open question. Can structured adversarial roleplay with a language model — skeptical, outsider, or edge-case personas — expose failure modes before human trials?

Testable idea. Compare solo revision of early-stage behavioral proposals with adversarial narrative simulation, rated blind by independent scientists for blind-spot identification and falsifiability.

Our note. The three named citations are verified. This is, in effect, a description of what we already did with Copilot and Gemini. It can generate designs and objections. It cannot replace measurement, and we will not treat this checkpoint, or the novel, as a completed test of that method.

4.7 Citations Gemini named that did not hold up, or that needed a name correction

These belong with the later directions (Section 5) but are recorded here because they surfaced as "existing papers to read first":

- **Godschalk (2012)** is verified. Hugo Godschalk, "Does demurrage matter for complementary currencies?", International Journal of Community Currency Research 16(D), 58–69. The journal's web header sometimes prints the name as "Godshalk," but the article byline, the requested citation, and the author's address (`hgodschalk@paysys.de`) all use Godschalk. DOI 10.15133/j.ijccr.2012.012 (the journal site resolves; Crossref did not return a work record for this DOI on the check date).
- **Champ, Freeman, and Weber (2003)**, offered as an experimental or theoretical paper on depreciating currency, is **unverified**. No 2003 paper by those three authors on demurrage was found. Champ, Freeman, and Weber (1999) is a paper on note redemption under the U.S. National Banking System, not on demurrage. Champ's relevant commentary on stamp scrip is later and sole-authored (Champ 2008, noted only as a lead; it is not used as evidence here because Gemini did not name it correctly, and we are not substituting a repaired citation into Gemini's list).
- **Ikkatai et al. (2023)**, offered as "experimental studies on depreciating currency (demurrage) and circulation velocity," is **unverified**. No matching paper was found. A later Bank of Japan working paper by Kota Ikkatai and colleagues (2024) is about unconventional monetary policy and the yen, not demurrage, and is not a substitute.

Until a primary source is produced, those two items stay in the pending list and must not appear in participant materials, pre-registrations, or any public claim.

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5. The three proposed directions

Gemini proposed three directions and picked Direction 2. We agree with that pick, and we fold Direction 1 into it as a daily EMA item rather than running it as a standalone first study.

	Direction 1. The Surprise Test	Direction 2. Dyadic Read-Back (chosen)	Direction 3. Demurrage stress test
One-line title	Does a "lack of surprise" mark, and can it interrupt, a self-generated inner voice?	When does a content-free check-in co-regulate without co-rumination or partner burnout?	Does a decaying, zero-floor token invite generosity or hot-potato gaming?

	Direction 1. The Surprise Test	Direction 2. Dyadic Read-Back (chosen)	Direction 3. Demurrage stress test
Why it matters	The novel's sharpest new heuristic has never been tested.	It is the load-bearing test of U5, and it guards the main real-world failure mode of "use a person as your key."	Orun's economy has never been run with real actors; U6 should not be built into an app until it is.
Sketch of a study	10-day EMA micro-randomization, 60–80 adults with ordinary brooding; surprise-test prompt on half of imagined-conversation episodes.	3-week field RCT, 40–50 dyads; constrained read-back versus unconstrained supportive check-in.	14-day online communities, 90–120 people; fixed tokens versus demurrage versus demurrage with a slower "rest" decay.
Main ethical risk	In bereavement, labeling a comforting voice as "only my mind" can cause a secondary drop. Needs briefing and a mood-repair close.	Relational asymmetry and emotional labor. Needs a daily cap and a right to decline.	Cash conversion can distort giving and create real financial stress. Tokens should not cash out; participation pay should be flat.
First paper named	Alderson-Day and Fernyhough (2015) — **verified**	Zaki and Williams (2013), with Rose (2002) — **both verified**	Godschalk (2012) — **verified**; Ikkatai (2023) and Champ, Freeman, and Weber (2003) — **unverified**
Our decision	Fold into Direction 2 as a daily item, not the first standalone trial.	**Chosen.** Draft protocol in Section 6.	Keep on the later map. Do not start until Direction 2 is either running under ethics review or has been fairly abandoned.

Gemini's reasons for picking Direction 2 still hold. It tests the central open claim of the unified paper. It confronts the failure mode that would harm the very relationships the framework is meant to protect. It is smaller, cheaper, and more clearly falsifiable than a token economy, and it does not require building a platform first.

Our one change is inexpensive and on-theme: add a daily Surprise Test item to the same EMA, so Direction 1 is not lost and does not compete for a separate sample. A later micro-randomized prompt can be added if the daily item looks promising. We also add an ethics gate that Gemini's 30-day calendar understated: real participants wait on formal review.

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6. The chosen direction: a draft protocol (not final)

This section is a working draft for later pre-registration. It is not locked, not ethics-approved, and not a treatment trial. Until an institutional review is complete, the only human use of these materials should be an informal dry run with consenting friends or colleagues who are told that it is a materials test, not a study.

6.1 Question and hypotheses

Question. In adults with ordinary (non-clinical) brooding, does a strictly constrained, content-free dyadic read-back reduce brooding without increasing partner burden, compared with an ordinary supportive check-in?

Draft hypotheses, all pre-registerable, all allowed to fail:

- **H1 (primary).** The constrained read-back arm will show a larger reduction, or at least no smaller reduction, in brooding on the Ruminative Responses Scale than the unconstrained supportive arm.
- **H2 (co-primary or key secondary).** The constrained arm will show lower partner-reported burden, and lower daily co-rumination, than the unconstrained arm.
- **H3 (secondary).** Perceived partner responsiveness will not be meaningfully worse in the constrained arm (a non-inferiority question; the exact margin is to be set at pre-registration).
- **H4 (exploratory).** On days when a participant notices that an imagined voice did not surprise them, or when they use the Surprise Test item, subsequent rumination will be lower, or defusion higher, than on days when an inner conversation is reported as still surprising. This is not a third randomized arm.

A finding that the arms do not differ on brooding, or that the constrained arm raises burden or lowers responsiveness, would count against a simple reading of U5 and would be reported as such.

6.2 The two arms

Participants. About 40–50 adult dyads (romantic partners, close friends, or housemates) in which at least one person reports frequent worry or brooding. Both members consent. This is a feasibility size, not a powered confirmatory sample; a power target belongs in the OSF pre-registration.

Inclusion and exclusion (draft). Adults; ordinary, non-clinical brooding. Exclude acute crisis, current mania or psychosis, and active prolonged grief disorder. That last group needs its own clinical study. Anyone who becomes unsafe during the study is withdrawn and referred.

Duration. Three weeks of field use, with pre- and post-measures, plus a brief baseline and exit questionnaire.

Arm A — Constrained call-and-answer. When either person notices drift or looping, they may start a short, procedural exchange only: “Where are you?” / “Here. Heard.” The person who was looping then names one physical object in the room (or in view). The pair does not discuss the content of the worry for 15 minutes. The script may be used in person or by voice; text is a fallback, not the preferred channel.

Arm B — Unconstrained supportive check-in. When either person notices drift or looping, they check in and may talk through whatever is on their mind, in whatever way they already offer support. No content window, no fixed script.

Both arms must be described, in every participant-facing sentence, as two reasonable communication habits. No sentence may say that the read-back is expected to work better, to "cure" or "stop" rumination, or to test a named philosophy.

6.3 Measures

Licensing and official forms are still to be confirmed before any use (this is a Week 1 task). Draft set:

Measure	Role	Source status
Ruminative Responses Scale, brooding items	Primary pre/post outcome	Treynor, Gonzalez, and Nolen-Hoeksema (2003), verified; license and exact item set to be confirmed
Perceived Partner Responsiveness Scale	Secondary, both members	Conceptual neighbor: Reis, Clark, and Holmes (2004), already in v1.0, pagination caution. The scale chapter is Reis, Crasta, Rogge, Maniaci, and Carmichael (2017/2018), looked up as the instrument source, verified on Crossref
Daily partner-burden item (responding partner)	Key secondary	Gemini named a "Partner Burden & Resentment scale" but did not give a source. **No instrument is invented here.** The item wording is an open decision (Section 9)
Daily co-rumination frequency	Key secondary	Rose (2002) is the construct source, verified; her full questionnaire was built for youth friendships and would need an adult, daily adaptation, to be specified later
Surprise Test item (daily EMA)	Exploratory (H4)	Novel-derived; unvalidated. Draft wording: "If you had an imagined conversation today, did the other voice say anything you did not already expect? If never, can you label it as your own voice in their cadence?"
SWEMWBS (7-item Warwick–Edinburgh)	Secondary well-being	Tennant et al. (2007); Stewart-Brown et al. (2009), both verified. Registration or license terms must be confirmed before use
UCLA-3 loneliness	Secondary	**Naming conflict, logged as an open decision.** Version 1.0 specified the 20-item UCLA Loneliness Scale, Version 3 (Russell 1996), verified. "UCLA-3" often means the 3-item short form (Hughes, Waite, Hawkley, and Cacioppo 2004), looked up as the usual referent of that name and verified. For a field study, the 3-item form is the lighter option; the 20-item form may still be used at baseline. Pick one and pre-register it
Feasibility	Use, answer rate, drop-off	Study-log counts, not a published scale
Optional, only if Direction 1 is later expanded	State Cognitive Fusion Questionnaire	Gemini named the instrument for a standalone Surprise Test study. The validation paper is Bolderston, Gillanders, Turner, Taylor, Ní Mhaoileoin, and Coleman (2019), looked up as the instrument source, verified. Not required for the first draft of Direction 2

6.4 Safety, 988, stop rules, and the partner cap

- **Crisis information.** Every participant and every partner receives the 988 notice at consent, at weekly contact, and at exit. If someone is in immediate danger, they are told to call 911. This study is not a crisis service and must not present itself as one.
- **Stop rules (draft).** Pre-set worsening of distress; emerging mania or psychosis signs; any safety concern raised by a participant, a partner, or the investigator; or a partner-burden threshold to be fixed at pre-registration. Any of these triggers withdrawal of the dyad and a referral, not a request to "try the card again."
- **Partner cap.** No more than two initiated check-ins per day per dyad, unless both people freely offer more. The responding partner may decline or delay without penalty and without having to explain the day's worry. That right is written into both consents.
- **Content-free window (Arm A only).** The 15-minute bar on rehashing the worry is a protection against co-rumination, not a gag rule about safety. If someone is in danger, the window does not apply.
- **"Drop everything" limits.** The author's P5 language, "drop everything for a real conversation," is a values statement. In the protocol it is bounded by safety, consent, the partner's right to decline, work and caregiving duties, and the participant's own needs. The study must never instruct people to ignore those bounds.

6.5 Neutral framing and what participants must not see

Participant materials will not use the words selu, eshva, rivel, Orun, C-R-Z, Zero-Velocity, Returning to the Living, or "living key," and will not include the novel, the unified paper, or a statement that connection is the only way out. The study is framed as a comparison of two communication habits: a short structured check-in, and an open supportive check-in. U5 may be the investigators' hypothesis; it is not a fact to be taught to the people being asked to test it.

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7. The 30-day plan

Roles follow Gemini's division, with one correction. Ryan Espinosa, as PI, owns ethics, recruitment, consent, safety, and final theoretical decisions. Grok Bot handles literature verification, alignment with the existing Return Card, and plain-language drafts. Gemini (in a later session) is asked to handle a pre-registration blueprint, a synthetic-data analysis script, and an audit of demand characteristics. Neither assistant is a co-investigator.

Ethics gate. Gemini's Week 4 opened recruitment. That is too fast if a university review is not done. The plan below keeps the weekly shape but makes recruitment conditional on approval. If approval is not in hand by Day 22, Week 4 becomes a freeze-and-wait week, not a launch.

Week 1. Pre-registration and protocol lock (Days 1–7)

- ☐ **Ryan:** Write exact inclusion and exclusion criteria, and finalize the 988 referral flow and the partner-decline language.
- ☐ **Grok:** Confirm licensing and official item wording for RRS, PPRS, SWEMWBS, and the chosen loneliness measure; format the two-arm pocket/phone instructions in plain language.
- ☐ **Gemini:** Draft an OSF pre-registration (sample-size reasoning, primary and secondary endpoints, the partner-burden threshold, and stop rules).
- ☐ **Shared:** Resolve the open decisions in Section 9 that block a lock (loneliness measure, burden item, whether v1.0 Phase A stays in the program).

Week 2. Instrumentation, ethics, and simulation (Days 8–14)

- ☐ **Ryan:** Identify an ethics or IRB path, preferably with a university lab; submit only when the protocol is stable. Set up a minimal-identifier survey or EMA pipeline.
- ☐ **Grok:** Draft plain-language consents for the primary participant and the partner, with no Orun or C-R-Z vocabulary.
- ☐ **Gemini:** Write a reproducible analysis script against synthetic dyadic data, before any real data exist.

Week 3. Dry-run of materials and an adversarial pass (Days 15–21)

- ☐ **Ryan:** Run a five-day informal dry run with three to five volunteer pairs who are not formal research participants, to test friction, timing, and the no-rehashing rule.
- ☐ **Grok:** Collect qualitative friction notes and revise onboarding where pairs slip into problem-solving or co-rumination.
- ☐ **Gemini:** Audit the dry-run copy so that Arm B is framed as positively and credibly as Arm A.

Week 4. Only if ethics approval is in hand (Days 22–30)

- ☐ **Ryan:** If and only if review is approved, open recruitment toward 40–50 dyads, take consent from both members, and collect baseline measures. If review is not approved, do not recruit; file the frozen protocol and wait.
- ☐ **Grok:** Keep a version-controlled study log and watch completion rates.
- ☐ **Gemini:** If data collection has legally started, run automated balance and data-quality checks. If it has not, stop at the synthetic-data rehearsal.

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8. Overclaims to retire, and the updates needed in version 1.0

Gemini listed four overclaims to drop before any launch. We accept all four, and we add the manuscript edits they imply.

In every participant-facing document, drop:

1. Any premise that a “living key” is already known to be superior. U5 is a hypothesis.
2. Any claim that a read-back “cures,” “stops,” or reliably breaks rumination. It is an attentional and conversational cue. It may fail, and it may feel intrusive.
3. Any universal wording of the form “only connection completes a purpose” or “only love remains.” Those belong in the values layer, not in a study.
4. All C-R-Z and Orun branding, including the novel, selu, eshva, rivel, and Zero-Velocity.

Queued edits for a later revision of the unified paper (version 1.0 stays the finished conceptual snapshot; these are the deltas):

1. Move the exclusive wording of P1, P3, and U8 out of the core proposition list and leave it only in the values layer (C1).
2. State the hot-potato and wash-trading risks under U6, and drop any hint of macroeconomic generalizability (C2).
3. Remove the mapping of UDL routes onto Pettigrew and Tropp’s contact theory as a prejudice-reduction path; keep UDL as accessibility (C3).
4. Replace v1.0 Phase B with this Direction 2 draft, including the partner cap, the decline right, the burden item, and the content-free window (C4). Keep Phase A (laboratory solo Drop versus control) only if the PI still wants it; that is an open decision.
5. Narrow the Feinstein et al. (2010) citation so that it cannot be read as support for “love remains” (C5).
6. Split the motor-interrupt claim into a phonological-loop neighbor and a separate, untested postural cue (C6).
7. Add Schooler’s meta-awareness caution to the “planned absorption with an exit cue” line (C7).
8. Note that Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) are now verified, and that Wörgl figures are still not (C8).
9. Keep the Novel Analysis’s list of places where the fiction is kinder than the evidence, including weak adversarial testing of the commons (C9, C10).
10. Record this checkpoint, the Gemini chat, and the chosen direction in the program history.

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9. Open questions and a decision log

9.1 Open questions

1. Which university or institutional partner will provide ethics review, and on what timeline?
2. What are the exact license terms for RRS, PPRS, and SWEMWBS?
3. Loneliness measure: Russell (1996) Version 3 (20 items), Hughes et al. (2004) 3-item form, or 20 items at baseline and 3 items daily?
4. What is the exact daily partner-burden item? Gemini named a scale that we could not identify from the reply. Do not invent a titled instrument.
5. Does version 1.0 Phase A (laboratory solo Drop versus a still-sitting or counting control) remain in the program, move later, or get dropped?
6. Should a later micro-randomization of the Surprise Test prompt be added inside Direction 2, or is a daily item enough for now?
7. When, if ever, to run Direction 3, and with what non-cash redemption design?
8. Should the Gemini review be repeated on a Pro model, and if so, how will disagreements with this checkpoint be reconciled?
9. Who, besides the PI, can see identifiable dry-run notes?

9.2 Decision log

Date	Decision	Status
13 November 2026	Version 1.0 of the unified paper is the finished conceptual framework. Further progress is measurement, not a new theory.	Locked in v1.0
13 November 2026	Gemini, under the Everyday help model, reviews the paper and the novel and proposes three directions.	Done; transcripts filed
13 November 2026	Adopt Direction 2 as the next empirical step. Fold Direction 1 in as a daily Surprise Test item. Keep Direction 3 for later.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Real participants require ethics or IRB review, typically with a university lab. Until then, only an informal dry run with friends or colleagues.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Keep Orun and C-R-Z branding out of all participant materials. Frame both arms neutrally.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Ikkatai (2023) and Champ, Freeman, and Weber (2003) are unverified and must not be cited as evidence. Godschalk (2012) is the verified first reading for later demurrage work.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Faith claims, including “only love remains” and “connection takes priority,” stay in the values layer. The 988 notice stays in every public document.	**Decided**

Date	Decision	Status
13 November 2026	Week 4 recruitment is conditional on ethics approval.	**Decided** (revision of Gemini's calendar)
—	Loneliness measure, burden item, and the fate of Phase A.	**Open**
—	File an ethics application; start Week 1 tasks.	**Not started** (this checkpoint was written first)

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10. References

Works are split so that nothing unverified can be mistaken for a source. Unless a note says otherwise, verified entries were confirmed on 13 November 2026 against Crossref, a publisher page, PubMed or PMC, or a record already verified in version 1.0 of the unified paper. Instrument-source papers that Gemini did not itself cite, but that we looked up because Gemini named the instrument, are marked **[instrument lookup]**.

10.1 Verified

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10.2 Pending or unverified

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Related works in this collection

- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living, version 1.0 (13 November 2026), with the Technical Companion and Analysis of the Novel. https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/orun-unified/Orun-Unified-Research.pdf
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, The C-R-Z Framework: Calibration, Reality-Return, and Zero-Velocity (13 November 2026). https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/c-r-z-framework/C-R-Z-Framework.pdf
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back: A novel of Orun (2026; some scenes first drafted with Microsoft Copilot).
- Google Gemini review session, “Everyday help” model, 13 November 2026, https://gemini.google.com/app/90c713738868da46, transcripts in this folder.

AI assistance

Grok Bot helped draft this checkpoint under the author’s direction, sent the prompts, and checked the literature. Google Gemini provided the external review, the three directions, and the first 30-day plan. Microsoft Copilot contributed draft scenes to the novel only. None of these assistants is a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence.

Values layer

The author holds, as a matter of faith, that all credit and glory belong to God. He holds that a higher power has overcome the world: “In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be of good cheer; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33, King James Version). He holds that respect for God and for the people who reach out to us means connection takes priority, within the limits of safety, consent, and one’s own needs, and he hopes that when memories fade, love remains. These convictions say what the work is for. They are not findings, and they are not hypotheses of the draft protocol.

> All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot; external review by Google Gemini. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text 988.